Table 19.1 Incremental steps toward strategic authorization. Organizations can enhance authorization capabilities by making targeted changes to address immediate challenges. Each step builds on existing practices, gradually strengthening decision infrastructure and governance without requiring a complete overhaul.

If you are here	You're likely seeing	A practical next step
Authorization logic embedded in applications	Inconsistent behavior across systems, hard-to-change rules	Externalize one high-value decision into a shared policy service
Multiple policy mechanisms across teams	Duplicate logic, outcomes that are difficult to reason about	Standardize on a common policy model and evaluation approach
Growing use of contextual signals	Ad hoc use of attributes, unclear trust in signals	Define ownership, freshness, and assurance requirements for key signals
Increasing delegation (partners, automation, agents)	Workarounds, over-permissioning, manual approvals	Introduce explicit delegation models with bounded scope
Policy decisions difficult to explain or audit	Support escalations, compliance friction	Capture and analyze decision logs to improve visibility and confidence
Policy changes risky or slow	Fear of breaking behavior, heavy review processes	Introduce testing, simulation, and staged rollout for policy changes
Organization recognizes authorization as strategic	Cross-team alignment, executive interest	Establish shared ownership between product, identity, and security teams

The steps in table 19.1 are intentionally modest. None requires a complete transformation. Instead, transformation begins with small architectural moves that make decisions visible, externalize policy, and strengthen how authority is defined and governed. Each reflects a pattern that organizations already encounter as their systems evolve. The goal is not to eliminate complexity, but to manage it more deliberately by making decisions visible, consistent, and adaptable.

As ACME's experience shows, progress in authorization results from aligning architecture, governance, and organizational understanding. The earlier this alignment starts, the easier it becomes to support new capabilities without creating friction or risk. The work is ongoing, but also cumulative. Each small improvement strengthens the foundation for the next.